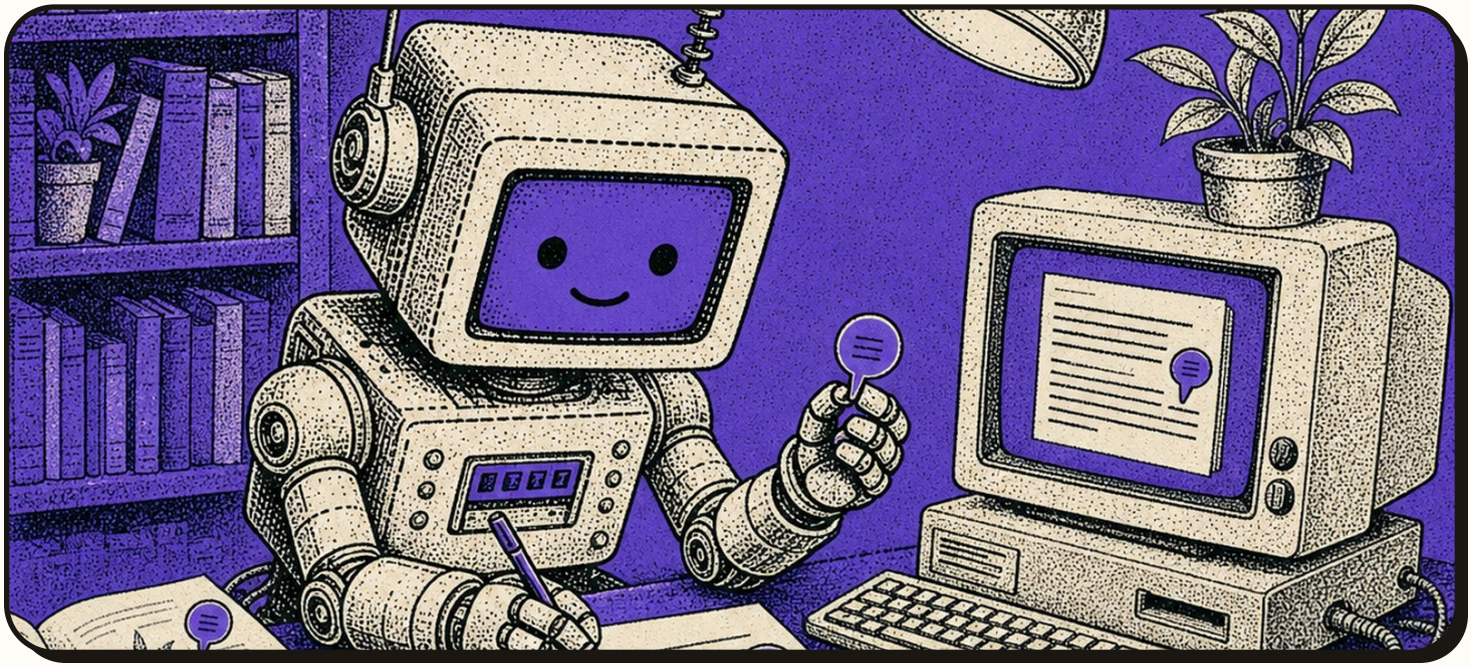
Good Websites

AUTHORITY CHECKLIST JULY 2026 / 10-POINT SELF-AUDIT

THE AI-CITATION-READY ARTICLE CHECKLIST

An evidence-led publishing audit for health content



BUILD AUTHORITY ON PURPOSE.

Create original, practitioner-led articles that answer real questions, support important claims, stay indexable, and give search systems credible material to reference.

10	CHECKS	5	FOCUS AREAS	1	ACTION PLAN

Start with a question worth answering.

Citation-worthy articles solve a real information need instead of chasing every keyword variation.

1 Choose one real patient question and purpose

WHY IT MATTERS

Define the audience, the decision or problem, and what a satisfying answer should help them understand. Keep the article aligned with the practitioner's verifiable qualifications, scope, and competence.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] One clear question anchors the article
- [ ] The intended reader is defined
- [ ] The topic fits the author's qualifications
- [ ] The article has a useful patient-first purpose

QUICK TEST Would the intended reader seek this answer even without search engines?

2 Give a concise answer before the deep explanation

WHY IT MATTERS

State the useful answer early, then add context, evidence, nuance, limitations, and next steps. Avoid forcing readers through a long introduction before addressing the question.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] A direct answer appears near the beginning
- [ ] Important caveats appear with the answer
- [ ] The opening matches the article title
- [ ] The rest of the article expands usefully

QUICK TEST Can the core answer be understood from the opening section?

Put a qualified practitioner behind the answer.

Clear authorship and original professional value help distinguish useful content from commodity summaries.

3 Assign a qualified author and reviewer

WHY IT MATTERS

Name the author, connect the byline to a detailed biography, and add an appropriate clinical reviewer when the topic benefits from additional oversight.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] The author is named clearly
- [ ] Author qualifications match the topic
- [ ] Reviewer is credited where appropriate
- [ ] Bylines link to substantial biographies

QUICK TEST Can a reader verify why these people are qualified to answer?

4 Contribute non-commodity professional value

WHY IT MATTERS

Add original explanations, frameworks, decision points, careful examples, or professional perspective. Do not merely rewrite the current search results in different words.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] The article contributes original value
- [ ] Professional insight is specific, not decorative
- [ ] Examples are useful and privacy-safe
- [ ] The article goes beyond common summaries

QUICK TEST What would another page need to cite this article for?

Make important claims traceable.

Evidence is most useful when readers can see which source supports which statement.

5 Use authoritative and primary sources

WHY IT MATTERS

Prefer current guidelines, systematic reviews, primary studies, government or institutional sources, and recognized professional bodies as appropriate for the claim.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] Sources are authoritative for the subject
- [ ] Primary sources are used when practical
- [ ] Evidence is current enough for the claim
- [ ] Source quality is considered, not just quantity

QUICK TEST Would these sources satisfy a careful reader checking the claim?

6 Place citations beside the claims they support

WHY IT MATTERS

Use descriptive links or reference markers close to the relevant sentence. Avoid dumping an unexplained bibliography at the end or linking to secondary summaries unnecessarily.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] Citations sit close to supported claims
- [ ] Links use meaningful descriptions
- [ ] Readers can reach the original source
- [ ] Sources are not misrepresented

QUICK TEST Can every important factual claim be traced without detective work?

Organize for readers, not AEO folklore.

Good headings, readable text, and useful depth matter; forced micro-chunks and AI-only rewrites do not.

7 Use descriptive headings and natural answer sections

WHY IT MATTERS

Let headings reflect the real questions and decisions in the topic. Use the length each section needs rather than splitting content into tiny artificial chunks.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] Headings accurately describe each section
- [ ] Questions reflect real reader needs
- [ ] Sections are complete without filler
- [ ] No artificial chunking is used for AI

QUICK TEST Does the structure improve understanding for a human reader?

8 Keep important information textual and accessible

WHY IT MATTERS

Publish essential facts in readable HTML text. Use relevant images, diagrams, tables, captions, and alternative text to support the answer without hiding it inside media.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] Core answers are available as HTML text
- [ ] Images add meaningful information
- [ ] Alternative text is useful and concise
- [ ] Tables and embeds work on mobile

QUICK TEST Would the article remain useful if the images failed to load?

Stay indexable, current, and measurable.

AI visibility still depends on foundational search eligibility and continued editorial maintenance.

9 Confirm search and snippet eligibility

WHY IT MATTERS

Make sure the page is public, crawlable, indexable, internally linked, canonical, and eligible to show a search snippet. Use only accurate structured data that matches visible content.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] Googlebot can access a working page
- [ ] No accidental noindex or snippet block exists
- [ ] Canonical and internal links are correct
- [ ] Structured data matches visible content

QUICK TEST Can Search Console confirm the preferred page is eligible to appear?

10 Review accuracy, AI use, and performance

WHY IT MATTERS

Disclose material automation use when appropriate, avoid scaled low-value publishing, review factual accuracy and Ontario advertising compliance, and monitor search visibility and useful actions.

CHECK FOR

- [ ] Material automation use is disclosed where useful
- [ ] Human review protects accuracy and originality
- [ ] Ontario advertising rules are checked
- [ ] Search and useful actions are monitored

QUICK TEST Is this article improving through evidence rather than publishing volume?

ADD UP YOUR SCORE.

Count the large checkbox on each item you can confidently tick today.

MY AUTHORITY SCORE

____ / 10

Fix one high-impact gap first.

0-3

Foundation missing

Resolve identity, access, accuracy, and essential trust gaps first.

4-6

Credible start

Choose the gaps with the greatest effect on patients and discovery.

7-9

Strong authority

Close the remaining gaps and make review part of normal operations.

10

Ready to compound

Maintain the standard, measure outcomes, and keep improving.

Your first improvement sprint

1. Highest-impact gap: _____

2. Owner + target date: _____

3. How success will be measured: _____

Want a second set of eyes?

Book a free 20-minute website review and walk through the checklist together.

BOOK A FREE CALL ->

GOODWEBSITES.CA

MEMBER NOTE: Educational only - not CONO approval or legal advice; registrants remain responsible for current standards, scope, and advertising.

GUIDANCE USED CONO: Advertising guideline | Google: AI optimization guide | Google: People-first content